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Bare-bones Retirement

In September 1986, Vicki and I lived for a week with a couple in Pula, Yugoslavia. Aldo, 58, and his wife, Dozanka, 57, speak a fractured mixture of Spanish, French, and Italian. Vicki and I understood only a part of what they said. But they let it be known that we should plan to be at the kitchen table every afternoon at five. At that hour Aldo would break out the white lightning, Dozanka would brew Turkish coffee, and the day's discussion would begin.

Aldo retired after 41 years in the merchant marine. He loves to talk about the countries he visited and people he met. He respects the intelligence of the Nazis who occupied Yugoslavia during World War II. He reveres Tito, Yugoslavia's great national hero, and compares him to George Washington. He takes pride in Yugoslavia's modern brand of capitalistic socialism. Aldo even thinks he understands the French, although he avoids saying too many kind things about them.

Aldo's two favorite countries are the Soviet Union and the United States. Both are big, rich, and high-tech. According to Aldo, Russia makes better cars. He's driven his Russian-built model for over twenty years, and it still runs perfectly. But Aldo prefers American TV programs, music, and sense of